

3.1a

Your CV/Resume

Business Builder
Teacher Resource Series

Worksheet

- A** Study these points about CVs (European style) and resumes (American style). Remember that there are no fixed rules and it depends on national culture and personal preference.

- ▶ Employment comes before Education, and the list starts with the most recent job/course first.
- ▶ Use short sentences and bullets and leave a lot of white space.
- ▶ Use action verbs (coordinated ... negotiated ... supervised ...).
- ▶ Use real results (increased sales by X% ... made savings of £Y).
- ▶ European-style CVs generally read like continuous text. They often include a short section on interests, sports etc. and sometimes give the names of referees (people who will give you references).
- ▶ American-style resumes are more like notes, are only one page long and do not usually contain sections on interests, sports and references.
- ▶ Some people like to mention their personal characteristics. The following words are typical:

highly motivated creative friendly and sociable perform well under pressure
good at taking initiatives efficient work well in a team excellent communication skills

- ▶ Common mistakes include:
 - Using too many long sentences rather than short sentences with action verbs.
 - Focusing on skills/abilities and forgetting achievements (concrete things you have done).
 - Including irrelevant information: short jobs/courses, lists of conferences etc.
 - Making the document too long: two pages (CV) or one page (resume) is usually the limit.
 - Stating your current salary.
 - Using too many character styles with the word processor. This becomes confusing.
- ▶ Recent graduates. If you are a recent graduate you know that at your stage most CVs/Resumes look very similar to an employer. For your CV/Resume to stand out you should consider the following:
 - Skills and abilities. Think of occasions in your life where you 'resolved a problem', 'set objectives to achieve a goal', 'met a challenge', 'worked in a team' etc.
 - Achievements. Even if you have just finished university, you can still think of concrete things you have done in the areas of project work, trips abroad, membership of a Students Association, sports, interests, hobbies.
 - Travel/Sports. Employers like to see travel (showing independence and self-confidence) and participation in sports (showing teamwork and sociability).
 - Translating names. Give the real name of the educational establishment and the qualification. Put a simple translation in brackets following the real name.
 - Grades. Every country has its own grading system, so put your real grade and then write it in brackets as a percentage or indicate the range.

- B** Look at the example on the next sheet. Does it follow the advice given in section A?

In the example there are lots of gaps. Write your name at the top and fill in a few of the gaps (use real or imaginary information). Then give your sheet to a partner and ask each other questions.

- C** Talk about – or prepare – your own CV/Resume.

